

Sculpting Light: The Akari Revolution

(Isamu Noguchi, 1951)

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Isamu Noguchi's *Akari Light Sculptures* exemplify the fusion of artisanal craftsmanship with modernist design principles which transformed a historically rooted, candle-lit lantern into a global, interior design icon. Perhaps otherwise lost to history, the 300 year old lanterns of Gifu, Japan, were revitalized and given a part in the country's postwar modernist movement. These modernized *Akari* lamps, produced using the same traditional techniques of the Gifu lanterns, have continued to be in popular demand since their invention in 1951. This reinvention helped preserve a fading craft, while pushing lighting design into new territory—where form and function became one, and light became sculpture.

A New Light: Inventing Akari

Noguchi, previously trained as an artist and sculptor, sought to rejuvenate the region's lantern-making industry by introducing modern innovations into both the design and the purpose of the lights. He envisioned a new form of the Gifu lanterns that would blend the traditional Japanese craftsmanship with modern aesthetics and function. Working closely with the local artisans, he retained the handmade qualities of the lanterns—still using washi paper and bamboo—but reimagined their shapes and functions to create sculptural forms that could be integrated into contemporary life.¹ He named the resulting designs *Akari*.

The choice of the name *Akari* reflects both a literal and philosophical engagement with light. In Japanese, *Akari* translates to “light” in terms of illumination and weightlessness.² This dual meaning beautifully aligns with the lamp's physical and conceptual identity—ethereal, almost floating forms that cast a gentle, warm glow.

Noguchi's use of the name speaks to his broader philosophy of merging East and West, tradition and innovation. The lamp embodied a certain philosophy; each *Akari* lamp channels *wabi-sabi*, a Japanese aesthetic centered on simplicity, natural materials, and the quiet beauty of imperfection.³ The texture of the washi paper, with its fibrous irregularities, absorbs and diffuses light in unpredictable ways, creating a living, breathing object.⁴ These small variations mean that no two *Akari* are exactly alike; rather than polished perfection, they embody the subtle beauty of asymmetry and impermanence.

¹ “Gifu Lanterns (Gifu Chochin),” Kogei Japan, accessed March 12, 2025, https://kogejapan.com/locale/en_US/gifuchochin/#_FEATURES.

² “Akari Light Sculptures,” The Noguchi Museum, accessed February 27, 2025, <https://shop.noguchi.org/collections/akari-light-sculptures>.

³ Mercer, Natalie. “Wabi Sabi : Beautiful Foolishness of Things.” Adorno Design, November 22, 2024. <https://adorno.design/editorial/wabi-sabi-beautiful-foolishness-of-things/>.

⁴ “Vitra: Akari Light Sculptures,” Official Vitra® Website UN, accessed March 12, 2025, <https://www.vitra.com/en-un/product/akari-light-sculptures>.

In contrast to the dominant modernist design language of the mid-20th century, which emphasized steel, glass, and stark lines, Noguchi's lamps offered an alternative: a version of modernity that was gentle, tactile, and deeply connected to natural materials and traditional craftsmanship. He rejected the notion that innovation must come at the expense of tradition. Instead, *Akari* became a reinvention—where the familiar form of the lantern is modernized not by erasing its past, but by elevating it through artistic reinterpretation.

This softer philosophy of design is also reflected in the way *Akari* interacts with light itself. Unlike many electric fixtures of the time, which cast harsh, directional light, the *Akari* lamp transforms artificial light into something closer to the natural warmth of the sun.⁵ The thin sheets of washi paper diffuse the light, softening its glow and allowing it to fill a room with calm ambience rather than clinical brightness. In doing so, Noguchi reshaped not only the object, but the experience of illumination—making it less mechanical, more meditative. The lamp became not just a functional fixture, but an emotional and environmental influence.⁶

The most pivotal innovations of the *Akari* lamp were Noguchi's decision to replace the traditional candle with an electric light bulb,⁷ supported by a discreet internal metal framework.⁸ This shift marked a transformation in how light could be experienced and sculpted. The new internal structure gave the lanterns a stability that enabled Noguchi to experiment with bolder, more complex forms that would have been impossible with the fragility of open flames. The electric bulb introduced a steady, controllable source of light that still interacted beautifully with

⁵ Isamu Noguchi, *Isamu Noguchi, Space of Akari and Stone* (San Francisco, California: Chronicle Books, 1986).

⁶ Trinity Trinity, "The Captivating Tale of Akari Light Sculptures: A Journey Through Time," *Vakker Light*, accessed April 19, 2025, <https://vakkerlight.com/blogs/news/the-captivating-tale-of-akari-light-sculptures-a-journey-through-time>.

⁷ Cajsa Carlson, "Isamu Noguchi's Sculptural Akari Lamps Are 'Poetic, Ephemeral, and Tentative,'" *Dezeen*, October 14, 2024, <https://www.dezeen.com/2024/10/14/isamu-noguchis-akari-lamps-ephemeral-mid-century-modern/>.

⁸ Lux, Moritz. "Sculpting Light." *some studies*, April 21, 2023. <https://www.somestudies.com/studies/sculpting-light>.

the translucent washi paper. These technological updates also helped position the lamps for a global market, making them safer, more durable, and more compatible with modern interiors. Western consumers, drawn to mid-century modernism's emphasis on clean lines and functional beauty, viewed *Akari* as a fresh alternative. In this way, *Akari* served not just as a source of light but as a design statement—that even the most ordinary elements of life, like light, can be reimagined as art.

With *Akari*, Noguchi distilled centuries of craft into a form that felt both ancient and utterly new. More than an object, each lamp became a vessel for sculpting light itself—a visual rendering of illumination shaped by paper and air. What began as a response to a declining local and traditional industry became an enduring global symbol of how design can illuminate not only space, but culture.

The Craft From Gifu

Before *Akari Light Sculpture*, there was the Gifu lantern, or Chōchin. Centuries before the invention, many parts of Japan displayed these lanterns. They were ingrained in traditional Japanese life and have been used both practically since the 16th century to illuminate homes and streets, as well as culturally or spiritually in festivals and ceremonies. The Gifu lantern is a handcrafted paper lantern produced in the Gifu Prefecture, located in the center of Honshu Island in Japan.⁹ They were initially invented during the Edo period when travel became popular and a portable source of light was essential. The Chinese characters “提灯” (chochin) combines the characters for “to carry in the hand” and “light,” directly reflecting its function¹⁰—people brought these lanterns to carry with them during their travels as they could easily fold flat.

⁹ David McElhinney, “What Are Chochin? Everything You Need to Know About Japanese Lanterns,” Japan Objects, May 24, 2024, <https://japanobjects.com/features/japanese-paper-lanterns>.

¹⁰ “Explanation of Japanese Lantern: History, Types & Where to Buy,” Millennium Gallery JP, November 19, 2024, <https://millenniumgalleryjp.com/en-us/blogs/journal/which-japanese-lighting-is-right-for-your-space-a-look-at-history-types-and-stores>.

These lanterns were primarily made from the Gifu region's local materials: mino washi paper, a material chosen for its extremely thin yet durable quality, as well as bamboo, used to form a delicate, circular framework. The production process of each lantern is meticulous and time-consuming requiring skilled craftsmen to carefully create one by one. Firstly, thin bamboo strips are wound around a wooden mold to create the frame. Secondly, layers of washi paper are applied to this frame using adhesive. Thirdly, some lanterns are hand-painted with intricate designs such as flowers, birds, and traditional landscapes. Finally, the internal framework is removed, leaving behind a delicate yet sturdy paper and bamboo shell. Decorative elements like tassels or wooden rings are added and the lanterns are illuminated by candles.¹¹

Used in essentially every context of illuminating spaces in traditional Japanese life, Gifu created the paper lantern industry. Ozeki, founded in 1868, was the primary manufacturer of these lanterns¹². However, after the second world war in the late 18th century, industrialization and electricity began to emerge and Japanese homes began to incorporate it. This meant a shift in preference toward cheaper, machine made goods. The abundance and ease of metal and plastic rivaled the labor intensive use of paper and wood. Consequently, the lantern industry also began a dramatic decline. To remedy this, in 1951 the mayor of Gifu invited a famous artist to present a solution, Isamu Noguchi, and the *Akari Light Sculpture* was born.¹³

Akari as Sculpture

The *Akari Light Sculptures* explicitly being called “sculptures”, and not merely functioning as a light, radically redefined the relationship between art and everyday life. While traditional Japanese culture has long valued the artistic quality of everyday objects—as seen in

¹¹ “岐阜提灯とは | 岐阜提灯協同組合,” 岐阜提灯協同組合, accessed March 12, 2025, <https://www.gifu-chochin.or.jp/about/>.

¹² “Ozeki: Gifu Chochin Letter Lantern,” Artisan, accessed March 12, 2025, <https://store.jtbusa.com/collections/j-flavor-ozeki>.

¹³ Alice Rawsthorn, “Isamu Noguchi’s Lamps Got Art and Practicality on the Same Wavelength,” The New York Times, July 11, 2008, <https://www.nytimes.com/2008/07/14/arts/14iht-DESIGN14.1.14431330.html>.

their tea sets, shoji screens, and calligraphy tools—this was the first instance in postwar Japanese design to assert a domestic object as a work of sculpture. So while lighting design may have previously been seen as an applied art, it was never seen as sculptural until Noguchi and in doing so, it merged Western notions of modern art with Japanese materials and tradition.

Noguchi's vision for his lamps was deeply rooted in his broader philosophy that "everything is sculpture".¹⁴ He strongly rejected the strict separation of fine art and functional objects claiming that the lamps could embody the same artistic integrity as his own stone and bronze sculptures.¹⁵ He argued for them to carry the same artistic weight as works displayed in galleries and museums.

The sculptural essence of *Akari* is evident in that he conceived these lamps as dynamic forms that interacted with light, space, and movement. Using the flexible materiality of the washi paper and bamboo, he could physically experiment and explore light as a sculptural medium similar to clay.¹⁶ Because each piece was handcrafted with subtle variations, no two lamps were the same—mimicking the craft of sculpture itself.

Noguchi's biracial identity as a Japanese-American artist also profoundly shaped his work. Navigating two cultures, he often felt like an outsider in both, which led him to seek synthesis through his art. The *Akari* lamps, rooted in Japanese tradition but embraced by modernist Western design, mirror this cultural duality. The hybrid nature of these lamps being functional and artworks embodies the idea that beauty and meaning can emerge at the intersection of different worlds.

¹⁴ Winther, Bert, Bruce Altshuler, Diane Apostolos-Cappadona, and Bruce Altshuler. "Isamu Noguchi." *Art Journal* 54, no. 3 (1995): 113. <https://doi.org/10.2307/777614>.

¹⁵ Lyford, Amy. *Isamu Noguchi's Modernism*. University of California Press, 2013, p. 145.

¹⁶ Kirsch, Matthew. "History of *Akari* Light Sculptures." The Noguchi Museum, January 10, 2025. <https://www.noguchi.org/isamu-noguchi/digital-features/the-history-of-akari-light-sculptures/>.

Tradition Meets Industry

In the aftermath of World War II, Japan underwent rapid industrialization and urban modernization, which prompted a national reckoning with its cultural heritage. During this period, Japanese design evolved to blend modernist influences from the West with their indigenous aesthetics.¹⁷ Noguchi, who had lived and worked extensively in both American and Japanese artistic spheres, became a critical bridge between these two worlds.¹⁸ With the invention of the *Akari* series, he embodied a bicultural perspective that allowed him to blend traditional Japanese materials with the sculptural abstraction of Western modernism. His ability to move fluently between these contexts positioned him uniquely to reinterpret craft as contemporary design. In doing so, Noguchi played a formative role in shaping Japan's postwar design identity.

Unlike many of his contemporaries, Noguchi approached modern design with a deep commitment to tradition. While other mid-century designers such as Charles and Ray Eames embraced industrial materials like fiberglass and molded plywood to produce sleek, mass-manufactured forms, Noguchi took a different path. He deliberately wanted to bring forward the traditional Gifu lantern materials and retain the handmade quality so that each piece continued to be produced as an individual work of art.¹⁹

However, maintaining this artisanal integrity became increasingly challenging as global demand for *Akari* lamps grew. As each piece continued to be handmade, requiring more intentional, time-intensive labor to match the output of mass-producing furniture manufacturers, the production process of *Akari Light Sculpture* needed adjustment. As *Akari* gained

¹⁷ Amy Sylvester Katoh and Shin Kimura, *Japan the Art of Living* (New York: Tuttle Pub, 1990).

¹⁸ Kida, Takuya. "Japanese Crafts and Cultural Exchange with the USA in the 1950s: Soft Power and John D. Rockefeller III during the Cold War." *Journal of Design History* 25, no. 4 (2012): 379–99. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/23353718>.

¹⁹ Kate Worthington, "Design DNA: The 'Akari' Lamp," *Elle Decoration*, November 2, 2021, <https://www.elledecoration.co.uk/design/a38136882/akari-lamp/>.

international popularity, Noguchi and his manufacturing partner, Ozeki & Co., faced the inevitable challenge of scaling production without compromising craftsmanship. They consequently made adjustments to production methods including refining adhesives and introducing standardized molds for each sculpture type—all the while, not losing the overall assembly by hand, preserving the integrity of traditional Japanese craftsmanship.²⁰ While many traditional craftsmen faced the challenges of keeping up in the new world of industrialization, *Akari* demonstrated how technological adaptation can sustain and even push forward the relevance of traditional crafts in a modern, globalized market.²¹

This thoughtful fusion of craft and innovation also yielded one of *Akari*'s most forward thinking features: its flat-pack design. The ability to collapse each lamp into a compact, lightweight form made shipping and storage remarkably efficient—an idea well ahead of its time.²² Long before flat-pack furniture became synonymous with global brands like IKEA, *Akari* was already demonstrating how thoughtful design could facilitate portability without compromising aesthetic value. The *Akari* emphasis on lightness therefore extends beyond the physical properties but conceptually too. This unique ability to fold into completely flat packages, was vital for bringing *Akari* to international markets and reflected a modern emphasis on efficient distribution without compromising its iconic designs—it was transportable and adaptable to a variety of contexts.

Akari Goes Global

The *Akari Light Sculptures* did not quietly enter the world of design but boldly stepped into both galleries and department stores—purposely contradicting the separation between

²⁰ Matthew Kirsch, “History of Akari Light Sculptures,” Noguchi, January 10, 2025, <https://www.noguchi.org/isamu-noguchi/digital-features/the-history-of-akari-light-sculptures/>.

²¹ Ettema, Michael J. “Technological Innovation and Design Economics in Furniture Manufacture.” *Winterthur Portfolio* 16, no. 2/3 (1981): 197–223. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/1180774>.

²² Lyford, Amy. *Isamu Noguchi's Modernism*. University of California Press, 2013.

commercial objects and high end art. Noguchi was highly intentional in his efforts to present *Akari* as a dual identity creation: a work of sculpture that belonged as much in a living room as in a museum.²³ He exhibited the lamps in esteemed institutions like the Museum of Modern Art in Kamakura as well as in upscale commercial venues such as Bloomingdale's.²⁴ This cross-contextual visibility was radical. It challenged entrenched hierarchies in the art world, which often drew rigid lines between fine art, craft, and design—and even more so between what was “authentic” and what was marketable.

This boldness however was not met without some controversy. In Japan, where lantern-making held cultural and spiritual resonance, some critics dismissed *Akari* as “deformed” versions of their traditional lanterns or that they presented a false, somewhat cliched image of Japan to the outside world.²⁵ Meanwhile, some western audiences felt unsettled by Noguchi's unapologetic embrace of the commercial marketplace—seeing him as an artist of his high caliber but selling his work in department stores.²⁶ And yet, this friction was precisely what made *Akari* so revolutionary. By inhabiting both commercial and artistic spaces, *Akari* dismantled traditional boundaries and redefined what it meant to live with art. It proposed that beauty shouldn't be reserved for elite spaces but could and should be a part of daily life. Noguchi wasn't “selling out,” instead he was expanding access. In a period when industrial design was leaning toward cold precision and mass relocation, *Akari* offered a warmer, more intimate interpretation of modernity: unadorned yet warm and modern yet rooted in nature.

²³ Kida, Takuya. “Japanese Crafts and Cultural Exchange with the USA in the 1950S: Soft Power and John D. Rockefeller III during the Cold War.” *Journal of Design History* 25, no. 4 (2012): 379–99. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/23353718>.

²⁴ “How Noguchi Created an Icon,” Barbican, September 30, 2021, <https://www.barbican.org.uk/read-watch-listen/how-noguchi-created-an-icon>.

²⁵ “Isamu Noguchi: The Sculptor as Designer.” MoMA, no. 4 (1977): 3–3. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/4380716>.

²⁶ Alice Rawsthorn, “Isamu Noguchi's Lamps Got Art and Practicality on the Same Wavelength,” *The New York Times*, July 11, 2008, <https://www.nytimes.com/2008/07/14/arts/14iht-DESIGN14.1.14431330.html>.

The *Akari Light Sculptures* played a pivotal role in reshaping the trajectory of modern lighting and furniture design by redefining the relationship between utility and art. They challenged the previously existing distinction between functional objects and fine art as it merged decor, utility, and artistry into a single unified form.²⁷ The soft, glowing ambiance and organic shapes were a sharp contrast to the era's other prevalent lighting trends such as sleek and mechanical looking desk lamps.²⁸ In doing so, *Akari* helped usher in a new design language—embracing fluidity, cultural hybridity, and the possibility that everyday objects could carry both practical value and poetic presence.

Overtime, many various designs inspired by *Akari* have emerged in the form of experimentations with new materials being used in the same spirit. For example, in 1952 George Nelson developed the Bubble Lamps; produced by Herman Miller, they used plastic-sprayed silk materials over a spherical metal frame.²⁹ Even contemporary designers still use *Akari* as inspiration, such as Ingo Maurer and the MaMo Nouchies series from 1998 which used hand-folded paper and hidden LEDs to mimic *Akaris* marrying traditional craft with modern function.³⁰

The Light Lives On: Akari's Legacy

Even in an era dominated by mass production, *Akari Light Sculptures* remain highly valued due to their handmade nature and historical significance. Collectors and design enthusiasts continue to seek out original *Akari* lamps. They are still produced by the same

²⁷ Claire Voon, "How Isamu Noguchi Sculptures Inspired the Paper Lamps We See Everywhere | Artsy," Artsy, May 28, 2018, <https://www.artsy.net/article/artsy-editorial-noguchi-sculptures-inspired-paper-lamps>.

²⁸ Beth Harpaz, "Noguchi Lamps Have Become Modern Home Classics," The Spokesman, June 2, 2013, <https://www.spokesman.com/stories/2013/jun/02/light-fantastic/#:~:text=Noguchi%E2%80%99s%20concept%20%E2%80%9Cstood%20in%20sharp,an%20international%20lighting%20design%20firm.>

²⁹ Betsy Reed, "George the First," The Guardian, June 18, 2005, <https://www.theguardian.com/lifeandstyle/2005/jun/19/shopping.homes#:~:text=George%20the%20first%20,though%20the%20material%20is.>

³⁰ "About the Collection Ingo Maurer MaMo Nouchies," Nostraforma, accessed March 13, 2025, <https://www.nostraforma.com/en/ingo-maurer/mamo-nouchies/>.

family-run Ozeki workshop in Gifu, maintaining their legacy as handcrafted objects in a world increasingly dominated by industrial manufacturing.³¹ Long before sustainability became a global design imperative, Noguchi was already practicing what we now consider eco-conscious design. The use of biodegradable materials like bamboo and washi paper helped to preserve tradition and reflected an early understanding of environmental harmony. In today's world, where designers seek alternatives to plastic and metal, Akari's materials and production philosophy have regained urgency. They serve as a precedent for sustainable practices, proving that ecological responsibility and beauty can go hand in hand. This commitment and enduring production run that has lasted more than 70 years speaks to Akari's timeless market appeal.

By the late 20th century, inexpensive paper lantern knockoffs had flooded the market, most famously IKEA's white paper shades sold for only a few dollars are direct knockoffs of the \$100-\$1000 Noguchi originals.³² All Akari-like lamps sold by other companies today were never officially licensed by the Noguchi estate to create these imitations but did so anyway. These mass market copies that made *Akari*s available to anyone worldwide cements their influence as most major lighting retailers offer an *Akari*-like lighting product. Not only did the *Akari* series achieve long-term commercial success but it influenced the product development of countless other companies, and continues to do so.³³

Now, the *Akari Light Sculpture* catalog includes over 100 variations of these lamps at different scales, colors, shapes, and uses. This includes designs from small table lamps to towering floor installations and delicate pendant forms.³⁴ This diversity reflects Noguchi's

³¹ "Production of the Akari Light Sculptures, Isamu Noguchi, 1951." YouTube, September 16, 2019. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hQ8SbDJ7Cck&themeRefresh=1>.

³² Claire Voon, "How Isamu Noguchi Sculptures Inspired the Paper Lamps We See Everywhere | Artsy," Artsy, May 28, 2018, <https://www.artsy.net/article/artsy-editorial-noguchi-sculptures-inspired-paper-lamps>.

³³ Jared Gordon, "Akari Light Sculptures," Consider, April 30, 2022, <https://considered.substack.com/p/consider-akari-light-sculptures>.

³⁴ Isamu Noguchi, Tod Williams, and Billie Tsien, *Quiet Light: An Installation of Isamu Noguchi's Akari Light Sculptures* (Tokyo, Japan: Gallery at Takashimaya, 1994).

imagination but also his commitment to making even the greatest extent of sculpture a part of daily life. Each variation is designed to suit a wide range of environments so that almost anyone can find a matching *Akari* for their home. This adaptability of *Akari* forms lies in their quiet and minimal presence. They compliment spaces without being overpowering, casting gentle light while offering an aesthetic focal point. Whether it be in a minimalist apartment or a traditional Japanese tatami room, they can be passionately displayed by their every owner. Owners of *Akari* often describe its effect as transformative—not just in illuminating space but in shaping emotion. Its soft, diffused light fosters a sense of tranquility, mindfulness, and warmth. This emotional resonance contributes to *Akari*'s longevity; it doesn't merely light a room, it alters the experience of being in that room. In a time when technology often overwhelms the senses, *Akari* offers a meditative counterbalance. These owners have described their *Akari* not simply as a lamp, but as a cherished object—such as an heirloom, a calming presence, or a living artwork.³⁵ In this way, the growing *Akari* catalog is a testament to the enduring relevance and flexibility of Noguchi's vision across generations, geographies, and lifestyles.

Isamu Noguchi's *Akari Light Sculpture* exemplifies the fusion of tradition and modernity, redefining the boundaries between art, function, and industrial design. By transforming Gifu's traditional lanterns into sculptural objects, Noguchi not only revitalized a declining ancient craft but also reimagined how lighting could be thought of as an artistic and functional element in modern interiors. His rejection of the rigid divisions between fine art and utility challenged conventional design philosophies and allowed *Akari* to exist as an everyday object and a museum worthy sculpture.

³⁵ Erin Schwartz and Lauren Ro, "Steal My Noguchi," *The Strategist*, June 7, 2023, <https://nymag.com/strategist/article/steal-my-noguchi-lamp.html>.

Beyond the aesthetic merit, *Akari* lamps highlight the endurance of traditional craftsmanship in an industrialized world. Despite widespread imitations and competition of light manufacturers that can produce designs at a much cheaper rate, original *Akari* lights remain highly valued due to their cultural authenticity and quality. *Akari* lights are the leading influence in which other light manufacturers have followed their lead.

Akari Light Sculptures are not just lamps but an incredible synthesis of tradition and modernity. They prove that true innovation doesn't have to discard the past but can reimagine it. In a world increasingly dominated by mass production, they stand as symbols of the fluidity between art and function as well as the value of human touch in design.

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